

finding justified the significant effort that went into creating them.

Days before the launch, the team realized the cards were too difficult to understand from their depiction on the website; people couldn't see how beautiful they were. They were also hard to produce. Cook realized that they had done the work backward. He explained, "Until we could figure out how to sell and make the product, it wasn't worth spending any engineering time on."

Learning from that experience, Cook took a different approach when he led his team through the development of a new set of features for a product that makes it easier to share photos taken at an event. They believed that an online "event album" would provide a way for people who attended a wedding, a conference, or another gathering to share photos with other attendees. Unlike other online photo sharing services, Kodak Gallery's event album would have strong privacy controls, assuring that the photos would be shared only with people who attended the same event.

In a break with the past, Cook led the group through a process of identifying risks and assumptions before building anything and then testing those assumptions experimentally.

There were two main hypotheses underlying the proposed event album:

1. The team assumed that customers would want to create the albums in the first place.
2. It assumed that event participants would upload photos to event albums created by friends or colleagues.

The Kodak Gallery team built a simple prototype of the event album. It lacked many features—so many, in fact, that the team was reluctant to show it to customers. However, even at that early stage, allowing customers to use the prototype helped the team refute their hypotheses. First, creating an album was not as easy as the team had predicted; none of the early customers were able to create one. Further, customers complained that the early product version lacked essential features.

Those negative results demoralized the team. The usability